

How To Build & Deploy a Static Website — Detailed Guide

From Idea to Live Website Using Claude Code · ThePrayingDoctor Ministry

OVERVIEW

Total time: 4-8 hours (spread across sessions) · Total cost: ~\$10-15/year (domain only — everything else is free)

Skill level: Beginner-friendly with basic tech comfort

What this covers: HTML/CSS/JS static site · custom domain · professional email · GitHub version control · Netlify hosting · logo branding

- Integrate
Claude
Claude Code
Convert PNG to SVG · Free
Embed version code · Free
Embed version code · Free (basic)
1. **Define your purpose** — What does it do? Who is it for? What problem does it solve?
Why: Claude Code works best with a clear vision. Vague ideas lead to vague websites.
 2. **Outline key features** — List everything you want before you start building
Why: A feature list prevents constant back-and-forth during development.
 3. **Choose your color palette & fonts** — Pick 2-3 colors and 1-2 fonts that match your brand
Why: Visual consistency makes a professional-looking site.
 4. **Decide on a domain name** — Short, memorable, and relevant to the content. Example: "Interactive Bible Map is a free ministry resource that lets users explore Scripture geographically and chronologically."

1. **Go to Namecheap.com** — Reputable, affordable domain registrar
Why: Reliable, affordable, and has a straightforward DNS management interface.
 2. **Search for your domain name** — Try .com first — most recognizable and trusted
 3. **Purchase the domain** — Use credit card or PayPal
 4. **Enable auto-renew** — Toggle it ON in your account settings
Why: If you forget to renew, you lose your domain permanently. Auto-renew prevents this.
 5. **Leave DNS settings alone for now** — You'll configure these later when connecting to Netlify
- Cost: .com domain ~\$10-15/year · Privacy protection (WithheldForPrivacy): usually included free

1. **Go to zoho.com/mail** — Sign up for a free account
Why: Gives you contact@yourdomain.com instead of yourname@gmail.com — looks professional.
 2. **Add your domain** — Click "Add Domain" and enter your domain name
 3. **Verify domain ownership** — Zoho gives you a TXT record to add in Namecheap!' Advanced DNS
Why: Proves to Zoho that you actually own the domain.
 4. **Add MX Records in Namecheap** — Zoho gives you specific MX values to enter
Why: MX records tell the internet "send emails for this domain to Zoho's servers."
 5. **Wait 15-30 minutes** — DNS changes take time to propagate
 6. **Complete Zoho setup** — Create your email address (e.g., contact@yourdomain.com)
 7. **Download Zoho Mail app** — Available on iOS (App Store) and Android (Google Play)
- ⚠ Note: Email forwarding requires a paid Zoho plan (~\$1-4/month). Free plan = send/receive only.

1. **Open VS Code** — Your coding workspace
2. **Create a project folder** — e.g., C:\Users\YourName\my-website
3. **Open Claude Code** — Ctrl+Shift+P ! type "Claude" ! open panel
4. **Describe your website to Claude** — Include: purpose, features, colors, fonts, examples
5. **Work iteratively** — Ask for one feature at a time — test it — then ask for the next
Why: Small changes are easier to test and fix than building everything at once.

Key files Claude Code creates:

- **index.html** — The skeleton/structure of your page (what elements exist and where)
- **css/styles.css** — The visual design — colors, fonts, sizing, layout
- **js/app.js** — The interactive behavior — what happens when you click things
- **js/locations.js** — Your data (for a map: location names, coordinates, descriptions)

Password Protection — Add to <head> of index.html:

```
<style>
  body { display: none; }
  body.authenticated { display: block; }
</style>
<script>
  (function() {
    let authenticated = false;
    while (!authenticated) {
      const pw = prompt("Enter password:");
      if (pw === "yourpassword") {
        authenticated = true;
        document.body.classList.add("authenticated");
      } else if (pw === null) {
        window.location.href = "about:blank"; break;
      }
    }
  })();
</script>
```

Why: Hides the entire page before the DCM loads — prevents flash of content before password check.

GitLab stores every version of your code. If you break something, you can go back. It also connects to Netlify for automatic deployments.

1. **Create account at github.com** — Free account is sufficient
2. **Create a new repository** — Click + (top right) !' New repository !' Name it !' Leave as Public !' Create
3. **Open VS Code terminal** — Press Ctrl+` (backtick key)
4. **Configure Git identity (one-time setup)**

```
git config --global user.email "you@example.com"
git config --global user.name "Your Name"
```

5. **Initialize and connect your project:**

```
git init
git remote add origin https://github.com/YOUR-USERNAME/REPO-NAME.git
git branch -M main
git add .
git commit -m "Initial commit"
git push -u origin main
```

git init = start tracking · git remote add = connect to GitHub · git push = upload files

6. **Authorize Git Credential Manager** — A popup appears — click Authorize in browser (one-time only)

For ALL future updates (just 3 commands):

```
git add .
git commit -m "Brief description of what changed"
git push
```


How To Build & Deploy a Website — Detailed Guide (continued)

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Netlify takes your code from GitHub and makes it a live website. Every push to GitHub automatically rebuilds and publishes your site.

1. **Create account at netlify.com** — Free plan is sufficient for static sites
2. **First deploy (manual)** — Drag your entire project folder onto the "Drag to deploy" section
Why: Gets your site live immediately while you set up the GitHub connection.
3. **Connect GitHub for auto-deploy** — Deploy Settings !' Link to repository !' GitHub !' select your repo !' Deploy
Why: After this, every git push automatically updates your live site.
4. **Verify the connection** — In Deploys tab look for: Production: main@[hash] Published
Why: the commit hash confirms Netlify is reading from GitHub, not a manual upload.

DNS is like a phonebook for the internet — it translates your domain name into the IP address of Netlify's server.

Go to Namecheap !' Advanced DNS

2. **Delete default records** — Remove parking page CNAME and URL redirect records
3. **Add these two records:**
Why: A Record points your root domain to Netlify. CNAME makes www. work too.
4. **Save each record** — Click the checkmark on each row
5. **Wait 5-30 minutes** — DNS changes spread worldwide — some locations update faster
6. **Test** — Visit yourdomain.com and www.yourdomain.com · Hard refresh: Ctrl+Shift+R

Use an AI image generator — DALL-E, Midjourney, Adobe Firefly, etc.

2. **Write a detailed prompt including:** — Site name and purpose · visual elements · color hex codes · style · usage size

Converting PNG to SVG using Inkscape (free, offline, privacy-safe):

Why SVG? Scales perfectly at any size — ideal for logos, crisp at all resolutions.

1. **Download Inkscape at inkscape.org** — Free, open-source, works completely offline
2. **Install** — Follow the installer wizard
3. **Open your PNG** — File !' Open !' select your logo.png
4. **Trace the image** — Path !' Trace Bitmap !' click OK
5. **Export as SVG** — File !' Export As !' choose SVG format !' Save
6. **Place in project** — Save as images/logo.svg
7. **Reference in HTML** — ``

Placement options:

- **Footer (recommended for busy sites)** — Groups logo + contact info naturally, keeps header clean
- **Header** — Better for brand-forward sites with simpler navigation

Cause: DNS records missing, wrong, or haven't propagated yet

Fix: Check Namecheap Advanced DNS — verify A Record (@ !' 75.2.60.5) and CNAME (www !' yourdomain.com)

Bypass: Wait 5-30 min, hard refresh (Ctrl+Shift+R), try incognito window

DNS records keep disappearing

Cause: Conflicting records (parking page CNAME or URL redirect overriding your A Record)

Fix: Delete ALL existing records first, then add only the A Record and CNAME

www.yourdomain.com works but yourdomain.com doesn't (or vice versa)

Cause: One of the two records is missing or incorrect

Fix: Verify BOTH records exist in Namecheap Advanced DNS

Cause: Tried to push before making a commit

Fix: Run git add . then git commit -m "message" before pushing

"fatal: repository not found" or YOUR-USERNAME still in URL

Cause: Remote URL has placeholder text instead of your real username

```
git remote set-url origin https://github.com/YOURACTUALUSERNAME/REPO-NAME.git
```

"Author identity unknown"

Cause: First-time setup — Git doesn't know who you are yet

```
git config --global user.email "you@example.com"
git config --global user.name "Your Name"
```

Push succeeds but GitHub repo is still empty

Cause: Remote URL was wrong during the push

Fix: Check `git remote -v` · fix URL · push again

Cause: Netlify still set to "Netlify Drop" — GitHub not linked yet

Fix: Deploy Settings !' Link to Git repository !' Select your GitHub repo

Verify: Deploys tab should show Production: main@[hash] Published

Site updates pushed but live site hasn't changed

Fix 1: Hard refresh (Ctrl+Shift+R)

Fix 2: Check Netlify Deploys tab — is there a new deploy triggered today?

Fix 3: If still showing "Last deployed from Netlify Drop" — GitHub connection incomplete

Deploy says "Published" but image/file is missing

Cause: New file wasn't included in the push

Fix: Run `git add . !' git commit -m "message" !' git push` again

Cause: Password script placed after HTML has started rendering

Fix: Move script to `<head>` with `body { display:none } — body.authenticated { display:block }`

Wrong password still loads the site

Cause: Script only checks once and falls through

Fix: Use a while loop that keeps prompting until the correct password is entered

Clearing browser cache removes password session

This is NORMAL behavior. Cache clear wipes session storage. Just re-enter the password.

Cause 1: File path wrong in HTML (check `src="images/logo.svg"`)

Cause 2: File not pushed to GitHub (run `git add . !' commit !' push`)

Cause 3: PNG format has rendering issues — convert to SVG using Inkscape

Logo appears but is tiny / barely visible

Cause: CSS height set too small

```
.footer-logo { height: 36px; width: auto; }
```

Inkscape Trace Bitmap looks noisy

Fix: In Trace Bitmap dialog, reduce Speckles threshold and increase smoothing.

Try "Brightness Cutoff" mode for cleaner results on logos with solid colors.


```
# First-time Git setup
git init
git config --global user.email "you@example.com"
git config --global user.name "Your Name"
git remote add origin https://github.com/USERNAME/REPO.git
git branch -M main

# Every time you update the site
git add .
git commit -m "Brief description of change"
git push

# Check what's going on
git status          # What files have changed?
git log             # What commits have been made?
git remote -v       # What URL is GitHub pointing to?

# Fix wrong remote URL
git remote set-url origin https://github.com/USERNAME/REPO.git
```

CHECKLIST — Is Your Site Ready to Share?

- Domain purchased and auto-renew ON
- Website built and hosted locally (no browser until correct password)
- GitHub repository created with all files (no password needed, working)
- Site pushed to GitHub (no password needed, working)
- Site pushed to GitHub (no password needed, working)
- Hard refresh tested after each change (Ctrl+Shift+R)

